

Sardinops sagax caeruleus

California pilchard



Length 10–14 in
(25–36 cm)

Weight 17 oz
(475 g)

Sex Male/Female

Status Not evaluated

Location E. North Pacific

This medium-sized silvery fish can be recognized by its distinctive black spots, arranged in rows along its body. In California, it is canned and marketed as the sardine, and is also extensively used to produce oil and fish meal. At one time, schools consisting of an estimated 10 million individuals were found. During the 1930s, over half a million tons a year were caught, but stocks dwindled during the 1950s, and collapsed completely around 1967. Today, the numbers of California pilchard are recovering, but stocks are still far from their original levels.

Denticeps clupeioides

Denticle herring



Length 3¼ in
(8 cm)

Weight Not recorded

Sex Male/Female

Status Vulnerable

Location W. Africa

This small, silver-colored fish is the most primitive member of the herring group, being virtually indistinguishable from fossil forms. Modified scales along the underside form backward-pointing serrations, and toothlike denticles cover the head. It also has a large anal fin. Unlike most herrings, it lives in fast-flowing, freshwater. It is also the only herring to have a complete lateral line (see p.486) running along its sides. This fish is omnivorous.

Pristigaster cayana

Amazon hatchet herring



Length 5¾ in
(14.5 cm)

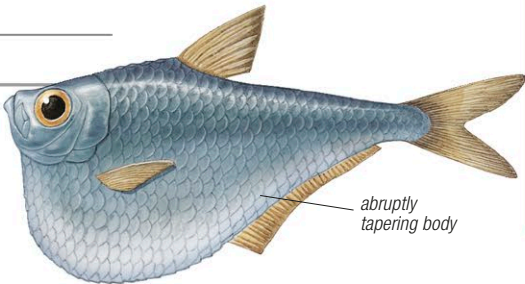
Weight Not recorded

Sex Male/Female

Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America

This thin, freshwater fish has a distinctive profile, with a deeply curving belly. Like many members of the herring family, its



Alosa sapidissima

American shad



Length 20–23½ in
(50–60 cm)

Weight 4½ lb
(2 kg)

Sex Male/Female

Status Least concern

Location W. North Atlantic, E. North America. Introduced to E. and W. Pacific

With its streamlined silvery body, the American shad looks like many other fishes in the herring order but it is

Engraulis ringens

Peruvian anchoveta



Length Up to 8 in
(20 cm)

Weight ¾ oz
(25 g)

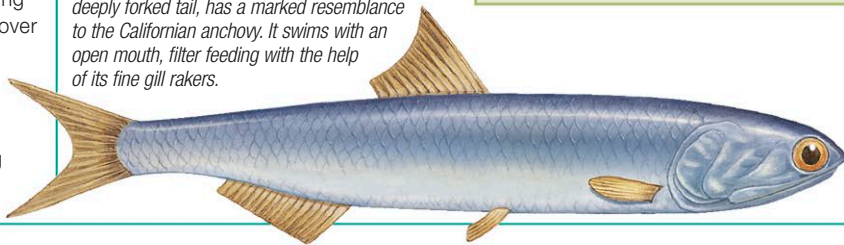
Sex Male/Female

Status Least concern

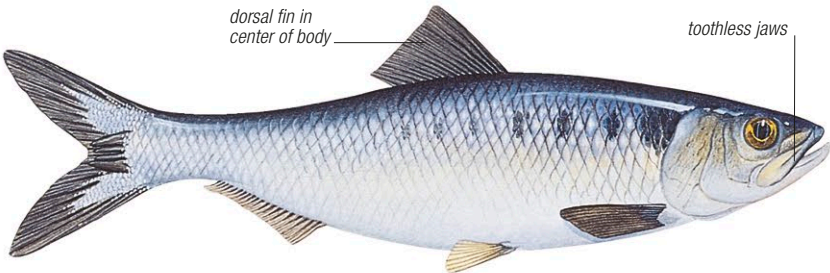
Location E. South Pacific

Like its close relative the Californian anchovy (see right), this small, silvery fish feeds on plankton, and forms enormous schools where upwelling currents create a good supply of food. Following the plankton as they migrate, they descend to depths of about 165 ft (50 m) during the day and rise to the surface at night. Peruvian anchovetas also school in huge numbers for safety. This fish spawns largely from winter to early spring.

SLIM FISH
This slender fish, with a pointed snout and deeply forked tail, has a marked resemblance to the Californian anchovy. It swims with an open mouth, filter feeding with the help of its fine gill rakers.



distinctive in that it enters rivers to spawn. Beginning at the age of 4 or 5, American shad migrate to rivers every year to spawn. Spawning occurs near the shore, after sunset, usually in late summer. Males arrive first, followed by the females, and pairs swim erratically near the surface with their dorsal fins



showing. Adults return to the ocean after spawning, and the young shad hatched out in the river migrate to the oceans in autumn. The numbers of American shad have suffered because of dam construction and water pollution. The Pacific populations of this fish have been introduced.

CONSERVATION

Despite its small size, the Peruvian anchoveta is one of the world's most commercially valuable fishes, with many millions of tons caught each year. However, its population is prone to sudden crashes, triggered both by El Niño—a periodic temperature rise in the East Pacific—and by overfishing. There have been major crashes in most recent decades, with severe repercussions for local people and marine wildlife.

Engraulis mordax

Californian anchovy



Length Up to 10 in
(25 cm)

Weight 1¾–2½ oz
(50–60 g)

Sex Male/Female

Status Least concern

Location E. North Pacific

This small but abundant fish is important commercially and a vital link in the marine chain, providing food for other fishes and fish-eating birds. Slender, with a distinctly pointed snout, it swims with its mouth open, filtering plankton from the water with its gill rakers. The Californian anchovy is one of about 150 species in the anchovy family, many of which are poorly known and difficult to tell apart. Anchovies are found in all the oceans of the world.



Chirocentrus dorab

Dorab wolf-herring



Length 3¼ ft
(1 m)

Weight 14 oz
(400 g)

Sex Male/Female

Status Not evaluated

Location Indo-Pacific

There are two species of wolf-herring, placed in their own family. It has an elongated, bright blue body and numerous teeth, with 2 fanglike canines protruding outward from its upper jaw. Unlike most herrings, it actively hunts other fishes. Little is known about the behavior of this species, but the fact that it is a large carnivore strongly suggests that it hunts alone or in small groups, rather than in large schools. Along with the closely related whitefin wolf-herring, it is extensively fished in some parts of the world.

